

Matthew 5:13 (pp. Mark 9:50, Luke 14:34,35)

¶ Ye are the salt of the earth: but if the salt have lost his savour, wherewith shall it be salted? it is thenceforth good for nothing, but to be cast out, and to be trodden under foot of men.

Read **Matthew 4:23-5:16**.

Note the context. Jesus is speaking to his disciples after going up into a mountain away from the multitudes. This verse occurs during what is commonly referred to as “the sermon on the mount” and directly follows what is commonly referred to as “the beatitudes.”

Note that **Matthew 5:13-16** are all one paragraph. (side-note: in the 1611 KJV the pilcrow/paragraph marker does not appear after **Acts 20:36¹**).

Think about salt and its properties, namely the effects it has on the things that touch it and surround it. Now think of disciples of Christ “sprinkled” throughout the world. Salt can be used as an antiseptic to fight infections and neutralize toxins and it can also be used to “bring out” or enhance the flavor of food that it comes into contact with.

In **Mt. 5:13** Jesus is likening his disciples (**Mt. 5:1,2**) to salt. Antiseptics are both “clean” and “pure” (**John 15:3**, **Col. 1:21,22**) and they prevent the growth of diseases (**1 Cor. 5:6b-7c**). Likewise, the behavior and prayers of disciples of Christ can have a profound impact on the people they come into contact with and the world around them.

John 15:3

Now ye are **clean** through the word which I have spoken unto you.

Colossians 1:21-22

And you, that were sometime alienated and enemies in your mind by wicked works, yet now hath he reconciled [22] In the body of his flesh through death, to present you **holy** and unblameable and unproveable in his sight:

1 Corinthians 5:6b-7c

Know ye not that a little leaven leaveneth the whole lump? [7] **Purge out therefore the old leaven**, that ye may be a new lump, as ye are unleavened.

But, what does Jesus mean here when he says “...if the salt have lost his savour...?” Salt is salt and it always tastes the same so He doesn’t seem to be referencing the literal flavor. If it’s not literal then perhaps it’s a symbolic parallel reference betwixt His disciples and salt?

The first biblical usage of the word “savour” and the phrase “sweet savour” occurs in **Genesis 8:21**. Read **Genesis 8:18-21** very carefully and take note of the order of events:

1. Noah, his family, and all the creatures exit the ark after the flood.
2. Noah builds an altar and offers sacrifices to the LORD.
3. The LORD responds with a promise, a covenant, and a token.

Genesis 8:18-21

And Noah went forth, and his sons, and his wife, and his sons' wives with him: [19] Every beast, every creeping thing, and every fowl, and whatsoever creepeth upon the earth, after their kinds, went forth out of the ark. [20] And Noah builded an altar unto the LORD; and took of every clean beast, and of every clean fowl, and offered burnt offerings on the altar. [21] And the LORD smelled a sweet savour; and the LORD said in his heart, I will not again curse the ground any more for man's sake; for the imagination of man's heart is evil from his youth; neither will I again smite any more every thing living, as I have done.

Psalm 51:15-16

O Lord, open thou my lips; and my mouth shall shew forth thy praise. [16] For **thou desirest not sacrifice**; else would I give it: **thou delightest not in burnt offering**.

Hebrews 10:5-8

Wherefore when he cometh into the world, he saith, Sacrifice and offering thou wouldest not, but a body hast thou prepared me: [6] **In burnt offerings and sacrifices for sin thou hast had no pleasure**. [7] Then said I, Lo, I come (in the volume of the book it is written of me,) to do thy will, O God. [8] Above when he said, Sacrifice and offering and burnt offerings and offering for sin thou wouldest not, neither hadst pleasure therein; which are offered by the law;

If God does not desire sacrifice nor delight in burnt offering and has no pleasure in burnt offerings and sacrifices for sin, then what did the LORD “smell” in **Gen. 8:21** that was sweet? Side-note: God is a spirit so I don't think it's safe to assume that He physically smelled the sacrifice.

John 4:24

God is a Spirit: and they that worship him must worship him in spirit and in truth.

Side-note: biblical usages of “savour” that convey the idea of a physical smell

Ecclesiastes 10:1

Dead flies cause the ointment of the apothecary to send forth a stinking **savour**: so doth a little folly him that is in reputation for wisdom and honour.

Song of Solomon 1:3

Because of the **savour** of thy good ointments thy name is as ointment poured forth, therefore do the virgins love thee.

The phrase “sweet savour” occurs 43 times in the bible and in every instance it is closely associated with sacrifice and worship (except *maybe* **2 Cor. 2:15**).

So, what then is this “sweet savour” to which God responds to with a promise in **Gen. 8:21** and to which it is possible for a disciple of Christ to lose?

In **Leviticus 26:31** we learn that a “savour” can also be referred to as a “odour” and the context (curses for disobedience which follows blessings for obedience) tells us that God will not “smell” the peoples “response” to their punishment following repeated chastisements. When God's people are afflicted, what do you suppose is an appropriate response assuming they want reconciliation? They will “cry out” or pray to God.

Leviticus 26:31 (read **Leviticus 26:14-39** for context)

And I will make your cities waste, and bring your sanctuaries unto desolation, and I will not smell the **savour** of your **sweet odours**.

In **Revelation 5:8** we learn that the four beasts and the twenty-four elders are holding harps and golden vials full of **odours**, which are the prayers of saints.

Revelation 5:8

And when he had taken the book, the four beasts and four and twenty elders fell down before the Lamb, having every one of them harps, and **golden vials full of odours**, **which are the prayers of saints**.

Lets go back to [Genesis 8:21](#) and apply what we've learned from scripture.

And the LORD smelled a sweet savour ;	And the LORD heard a prayer of a saint
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Remember that there were only eight souls on the ark ([Genesis 7:7](#), [1 Peter 3:20](#)). Think of the tremendous loss that Noah was burdened with. What do you think that Noah would have prayed for at that alter to which the LORD responded with a promise ([Genesis 8:21](#)), a covenant, and a token ([Genesis 9:8-17](#))?

Numerous verses convey to us the importance of prayers. Here are a few:

John 15:5 I am the vine, ye are the branches: He that abideth in me, and I in him, the same bringeth forth much fruit: for without me ye can do nothing .	Philippians 4:6 Be careful for nothing; but in every thing by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known unto God.
Luke 18:1 And he spake a parable unto them to this end, that men ought always to pray , and not to faint;	1 Thessalonians 5:17 Pray without ceasing .
Jeremiah 33:3 Call unto me, and I will answer thee, and shew thee great and mighty things, which thou knowest not.	Psalm 116:2 Because he hath inclined his ear unto me, therefore will I call upon him as long as I live .
Ephesians 6:18 KJV Praying always with all prayer and supplication in the Spirit, and watching thereunto with all perseverance and supplication for all saints;	Psalm 86:3 Be merciful unto me, O Lord: for I cry unto thee daily .

Going back to [Matthew 5:13](#) and applying what we've learned from scripture: what then could a disciple of Christ "lose" that would make them "good for nothing"?

If our means through which we "bear much fruit" ([John 15:8](#)) is Christ ([John 15:5](#)) and our method is to pray in the name of Jesus Christ I think the answer becomes clear: prayer!

Thus, we conclude: if a disciple of Christ ceases to pray – they can become "good for nothing", or worse "cast out".

In light of all we have learned, [Matthew 5:13](#) becomes an encouragement from Christ to His disciples to pray.

¹<http://av1611blogger.blogspot.com/2013/07/why-do-paragraph-marks-stop.html>